

RISHAB SHETTY

↘ *Kantara* (2022)

A drama/thriller set around the 'boota kola' tradition, *Kantara* was written and directed by Rishab Shetty, who also plays the lead in it; Raj B. Shetty shot a few scenes

↘ *Bell Bottom* (2019)

Directed by Jayathirtha B.V., *Bell Bottom* is a detective-comedy film, which has Rishab in the lead role



RAKSHIT SHETTY

↘ *Ulidavaru Kandanthe* (2014)

A gangster film set in Udupi, *Ulidavaru Kandanthe* was written and directed by Rakshit Shetty, and starred both him and Rishab Shetty

↘ *Kirik Party* (2016)

A college romance film written by and starring Rakshit, directed by Rishab

↘ *777 Charlie* (2022)

While Rakshit produced this adventure-drama as well as starred in it, the film was written and directed by Kiranraj K.; Raj B. Shetty collaborated on dialogues



RAJ B. SHETTY

↘ *Ondu Motteya Kathe* (2017)

Raj B. Shetty wrote, directed and starred in this romantic comedy about a bald lecturer in Mangaluru

↘ *Garuda Gamana Vrishabha Vahana* (2021)

With Raj and Rishab Shetty in lead roles, this gangster film is set in Mangaluru and has been written and directed by Raj himself

were familiar with their work back then. And yet, *Kantara*, coming eight years later, is no flash in the pan. A new wave of Kannada cinema, which started with Pawan Kumar's *Lucia* (2013), a crowd-funded film that upended conventional cinema tropes, was perhaps the first hint of the success that was to grace the Kannada film industry years later. The Shettys contributed to it by making films packed with local flavour that revealed little-explored parts of the state. Take, for instance, Raj B. Shetty's 2021 flick *Garuda Gamana Vrishabha Vahana* (GGVV), which offers a micro-history of coastal Mangaluru through the crimes and misdemeanours of friends-turned-foes (played by Raj and Rishab). There's also Rakshit's *777 Charlie* (2022), about a lonely factory worker and a Labrador dog.

The Shettys, interestingly, are unique because they don't just act in and produce but also write and direct films. Before bagging a minor role of a police officer in *Lucia*, Rishab had done three films, including one with Rakshit. That film, *Tuglak* (2012), failed, but it cemented their friendship. "We used to sit outside the theatre waiting for people to turn up," recalls Rakshit. Discussing scripts, the duo first set out to work on a short film before taking up *Ulidavaru Kandanthe*. "I thought I should probably write something for myself where I can show my potential as an actor. That's the reason I started writing," says Rakshit.

Ulidavaru Kandanthe, with Rakshit directing, Rishab assisting and both acting, didn't do well at the box office either, but it became a cult favourite. Set in Udupi, from where the two hailed, the movie broke with convention: it was possibly the first commercial film to showcase the Mangaluru region's own milieu and dialect, which is distinct from the Kannada spoken elsewhere. These had so far remained neglected in mainstream cinema, to the extent that the Mangaluru accent, whenever it was deployed, usually served as mere comic relief. Yet, Kannada arthouse cinema frequently explored themes from these regions. "It was a surprise that he [Rakshit] did something so ambitious for his first film," says filmmaker Srinivas Bhashyam, who has assisted the likes of Girish Kasaravalli and Mani Ratnam. "It was an inventive, non-linear and witty narrative. And while a Tarantino-esque influence was obvious, he also used music very enthusiastically, like the best of mainstream cinema."

A key realisation for the Kannada film industry was that even small-budget films with engaging themes can shine at the box office, and it came in 2017 with Raj B. Shetty's *Ondu Motteya Kathe* (Story of a Bald Man), which was about a bald lecturer in the sleepy city of Mangaluru. Raj, who was until then a newcomer, followed up on the Mangaluru theme with *GGVV*, which won